



MWC PREVIEW



PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH

	1	UNLV REBELS
	2	NEW MEXICO LOBOS
	3	HAWAI'I RAINBOW WARRIORS
	4	NORTH DAKOTA STATE BISON
	5	AIR FORCE FALCONS
	6	WYOMING COWBOYS
	7	NEVADA WOLF PACK
	8	SAN JOSÉ STATE SPARTANS
	9	UTEP MINERS
	10	NORTHERN ILLINOIS HUSKIES

MWC CHAMPIONSHIP

UNLV OVER NEW MEXICO



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT STEVEN LASSAN AT **ATHLONSPORTS.COM** FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-MWC TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	MICAH ALEJADO	Hawai'i
RB	JAI'DEN THOMAS	UNLV
RB	OWEN ALLEN	Air Force
AP	SCOTTRE HUMPHREY	New Mexico
WR	POFELE ASHLOCK	Hawai'i
WR	TROY OMEIRE	New Mexico
WR	AUDRIC HARRIS	Hawai'i
TE	CADE KEITH	New Mexico
C	KADEN ROBNETT	New Mexico
OL	JACK FOSTER	Nevada
OL	AUSTIN BOYD	UNLV
OL	GRIFFIN EMPEY	North Dakota State
OL	ZACH COCHNAUER	Nevada

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	DYLAN LABARBERA	Nevada
DL	KEENAN WILSON	North Dakota State
DL	LUCAS CONTI	UNLV
DL	DARREN AGU	New Mexico
LB	JAXTON ECK	New Mexico
LB	BLAKE FLETCHER	Air Force
LB	ISAAC HUBERT	Air Force
LB	DONOVAN WOOLEN	North Dakota State
CB	ELIJAH PALMER	Hawai'i
CB	DESMAN HEARNS	Wyoming
S	ROGER JONES JR.	Air Force
S	AUSTIN BRAWLEY	New Mexico

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	JOE McFADDEN	Nevada
P	BART EDMISTON	Wyoming
KR	JACKSON WILLIAMS	North Dakota State
PR	JACKSON WILLIAMS	North Dakota State

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Poinsettia: UNLV vs. San Diego State

Famous Idaho Potato: North Dakota State vs. Toledo

Hawai'i: Hawai'i vs. UCLA

Arizona: Air Force vs. Ohio

New Mexico: New Mexico vs. UTSA



MICAH ALEJADO, HAWAII

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

AIR FORCE

Defense: New: Steve Russ

Old: Brian Knorr

NEVADA

Offense: New: Brett Bartolone

Old: David Gilbertson

NORTHERN ILLINOIS

Offense: New: Tony Petersen, Quinn

Sanders; Old: Quinn Sanders

SAN JOSÉ STATE

Defense: New: Bojay Filimoeatu

Old: Derrick Odum

UTEP

Offense: New: Joe Pappalardo, Lanear

Sampson; Old: Mark Cala

Defense: New: Kyle Beyer, Kelvin Sigler

Old: Bobby Daly

WYOMING

Offense: New: Christian Taylor

Old: Jay Johnson



STEVE RUSS, AIR FORCE

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Jordan Njoku	LB	UNLV	★★★	600
2. Jesse Harden	WR	UNLV	★★★	688
3. Colin Ford	TE	Wyoming	★★★	761
4. Bryshawn Brown	QB	Northern Illinois	★★★	926
5. Aveon Williams	ATH	UNLV	★★★	970

JAXTON ECK, NEW MEXICO
JACKSON ARNOLD, UNLV



TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. Jackson Arnold	QB	UNLV	Auburn
The former 5-star lands in head coach Dan Mullen's QB-friendly attack.			
2. Tyler Hughes	QB	Wyoming	William & Mary
A dual-threat in the FCS, Hayes adds a wrinkle to a lackluster offense.			
3. EJ Colson	QB	UTEP	Incarnate Word
Colson brings high-level accuracy to a team plagued by persistent turnovers.			
4. Troy Omeire	WR	New Mexico	UNLV
Omeire is a well-traveled contested-catch specialist.			
5. Audric Harris	WR	Hawai'i	Washington
Harris brings Power 4 experience to a rebuilt receiver room in a pass-happy offense.			
6. Caleb Brown	CB	Hawai'i	Virginia Tech
Brown is back in the Aloha State to strengthen a secondary in transition.			
7. Markell Holman	RB	Wyoming	Western Illinois
Holman handled a heavy workload and led the FCS OVC in rushing with 1,064 yards.			
8. Taz Reddicks	WR	UNLV	Oregon State
Reddicks' arrival helps fill a position of need for the Rebels' high-flying offense.			
9. Kene Anene	OL	North Dakota State	Kansas
Anene brings FBS experience to the trenches to help ease the Bison's transition.			
10. Jacob Norcross	OL	Nevada	Memphis
Decorated protector returns to his home state to provide stability up front.			

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. UNLV (69)	5. Nevada (93)	9. San José State (128)
2. New Mexico (70)	6. North Dakota State (100)	10. Air Force (138)
3. Northern Illinois (77)	7. Wyoming (106)	
4. UTEP (91)	8. Hawai'i (127)	

Rankings per Rivals;
National ranking in parentheses

GAMES TO WATCH

Aug. 29 Memphis at UNLV

Aug. 29 Hawai'i at Stanford

Sept. 5 UNLV at Hawaii

Sept. 5 Wyoming at Colorado State

Sept. 26 New Mexico at New Mexico St.

Oct. 3 Cal at UNLV

Oct. 3 Navy at Air Force

Oct. 10 Hawai'i at Arizona State

Oct. 17 New Mexico at Hawai'i

Nov. 7 Air Force at Army

Nov. 14 UNLV at New Mexico

Nov. 14 North Dakota State at Hawai'i

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Cade Mitchell	QB	New Mexico	★★★	1,038
7. Tatum Bell Jr.	WR	UNLV	★★★	1,060
8. Malik White	IOL	UNLV	★★★	1,155
9. Perrion Williams	WR	Nevada	★★★	1,189
10. Derek Garcia	QB	UNLV	★★★	1,235

Rankings per Rivals industry ranking;

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: MARCO GARCIA-IMAGN IMAGES; MARK J. REBELAS-IMAGN IMAGES; JOHN REED-IMAGN IMAGES; RON CHENOV-USA TODAY SPORTS



AIR FORCE FALCONS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 80 | MWC PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 3-5 MWC

OFFENSE Air Force found its quarterback of the future last season, and the Falcons should look forward to two more years of Liam Szarka. The junior saw action in 10 games last season before breaking his wrist. He led the Mountain West Conference with 13 rushing touchdowns, was second in the league with 92.2 rushing yards per game and threw nine touchdowns to five interceptions. In each of his first three career starts, he threw for 200-plus yards and rushed 110-plus yards in each, the best three-game start for an Air Force QB in program history.

AFA's second-leading rusher also returns in Owen Allen. The fullback produced five 100-yard games last year.

The offensive line lost two All-MWC players, but two full-time starters are back, along with senior Luke Vonderhaar, who has extensive experience. Expect the Falcons to reload along the line.

The biggest question heading into the fall is the receiver unit, with Jonah Dawson the leading returner with 12 receptions, but AFA runs the ball 80% of the time.

DEFENSE Air Force fell to 10th in the league in total defense last season and allowed 30.3 points per game, as young players took their lumps.

The unit should be markedly improved this season with almost the entire back eight intact after a season of growing pains. Inside linebacker Blake Fletcher was second-team All-MWC last season and should compete for first-team honors after leading the team with 108 tackles. Dallas Daley and Isaac Hubert will be alongside Fletcher in what is expected to be a very solid linebacking corps.

Safety Roger Jones Jr. was an honorable mention All-MWC selection last season and headlines a backline with a ton of returning experience. Corners Mikhail Seiken and Corey Johnson are tested, and safety Max Mustell picked off three passes as a true freshman.

Graduation wiped out the defensive line, and Air Force does not take transfers, so the Falcons will be inexperienced up front.

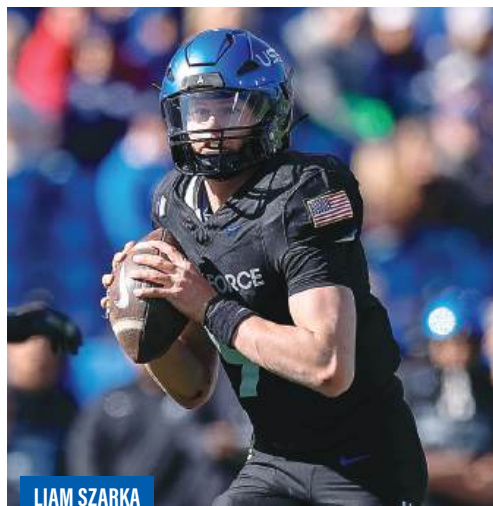
SPECIALISTS Placekicker Jacob Medina was first-string last season coming out of camp, but he lost his job after missing half of his six field-goal attempts. He had a solid spring and is once again the No. 1 kicker. Will Duncan will be the new punter.

FINAL ANALYSIS After two straight losing seasons, the arrow is pointing up for head coach Troy Calhoun in his 20th season. A veteran quarterback, an experienced defense and a conference that has bid farewell to Boise State and San Diego State, among others, give Air Force the chance to get back over .500 and compete for a top-three spot in the Mountain West.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 3-5 MWC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Bucknell W 49-13	Sept. 5 Duquesne	1. Knight Wilson, S ★★★
Sept. 13 at Utah State L 30-49	Sept. 12 North Dakota State	2. Merrik Bloomgren, WR ★★★
Sept. 20 Boise State L 37-49	Sept. 26 at Nevada	3. Wes Burford, ATH ★★★
Sept. 27 Hawai'i L 35-44	Oct. 3 Navy	4. Blaze Jones, EDGE ★★★
Oct. 4 at Navy L 31-34	Oct. 10 at Northern Illinois	5. Case Vanden Bosch, QB ★★★
Oct. 11 at UNLV L 48-51	Oct. 17 UNLV	6. Damian Horace, S ★★★
Oct. 18 Wyoming W 24-21	Oct. 24 at Wyoming	7. Dominic Basrawala, EDGE ★★★
Nov. 1 Army L 17-20	Oct. 31 UConn	8. Kobe Dooley, WR ★★★
Nov. 8 at San José State W 26-16	Nov. 7 at Army	9. Brody Sieck, EDGE ★★★
Nov. 15 at UConn L 16-26	Nov. 14 San José State	10. Xander Shaw, DL ★★★
Nov. 22 New Mexico L 3-20	Nov. 21 UTEP	
Nov. 28 at Colorado State W 42-21	Nov. 28 at New Mexico	

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Troy Calhoun • Record at School: 139-97 (19 years) • Career Record: 139-97 (19 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Mike Thiessen • Defensive Coordinator: Steve Russ • Location: Colorado Springs, Colo. • Stadium: Falcon Stadium (39,441)



LIAM SZARKA

SCOUTING THE FALCONS

"Honestly, it's really cool that they don't do the transfer portal. They're not gonna make mistakes, and when you make a mistake, they're gonna make you pay for it. If you turn the ball over against them, it'll kill ya because they're a possession-based team. ... A lot of kids these days who are signing out of high school to go to a Mountain West school, they're happy to go there, but in two or three years, give them truth serum and they'd like to be at a Power 4 school. A lot of [Air Force recruits] are thinking, 'I want to serve.' They recruit a specific type of kid. Now, there's enough evidence that you can still, if you end up being a heck of a ballplayer, reach your NFL dreams and stay there."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	8	Jonah Dawson (Jr.)	10	Adam Hrynciw (Sr.)
WR	3	Matt Long (Jr.)	18	Mason Hayes (Jr.)
LT	52	NATHAN ELWOOD (SR.)	73	Brandon Nazworth (Jr.)
LG	58	TJ Tarascio (Sr.)	75	ALEC FALK (SR.)
C	51	Rudy Varela (Sr.)	59	Johnique Thomas (Jr.)
RG	72	Jon Ashford (Jr.)	57	Brody Smith (Jr.)
RT	55	Luke Vonderhaar (Sr.)	71	Marcus Roser (Jr.)
TE	80	Simon Kibbee (Sr.)	86	Griffin Stalford (Sr.)
QB	9	LIAM SZARKA (JR.)	11	Josh Johnson (Sr.)
FB	2	Owen Allen (Sr.)	28	Gage LaDue (Jr.)
TB	44	Rocco Conti (Sr.)	26	Jalen Rashad Turner (Sr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	50	Grady Forsythe (Jr.)	45	Jaylin Reese (Jr.)
NG	97	Bennett Williams (Jr.)	99	Jayden Oquendo (Sr.)
DT	59	Chaz Barnett (Jr.)	93	Andrew Tillett (Sr.)
OLB	30	ISAAC HUBERT (SR.)	92	Connor Vasek (So.)
MLB	6	BLAKE FLETCHER (SR.)	0	Luke Fisher (Sr.)
OLB	8	Dallas Daley (Sr.)	51	Vinnie Canosa (Jr.)
CB	2	Korey Johnson (Jr.)	10	Jerome Drain (So.)
CB	4	MIKHAIL SEIKEN (JR.)	9	Jaris McIntosh (Sr.)
NB	26	Alexander Perez (So.)	31	Jayden Malbranche (So.)
SS	5	ROGER JONES JR. (JR.)	19	Houston Hendrix (Sr.)
FS	25	Cade Paterson (So.)	36	MAX MUSTELL (SO.)

SPECIALISTS

K	39	Jacob Medina (Jr.)	KR	3	Matt Long (Jr.)
P	94	Will Duncan (Jr.)	PR	3	Matt Long (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD

ISAIAH J. DOWNING-IMAGI IMAGES



MICAH ALEJADO

SCOUTING THE RAINBOW WARRIORS

"They're absolutely a legitimate contender in the Mountain West. That home-field advantage is real. That culture, they play hard, hard, hard. [Head coach] Timmy Chang being an alumni there, he just gets it. ... I'm sure that they'll find athletes and guys to replace what they lost on the defensive side. ... That quarterback [Micah Alejado] is legit. The system, the 'Spread N' Shred,' it works, and when it's clicking on all cylinders, it's hard to defend. [Alejado] was only a redshirt freshman, and he knew where to go with the ball. He made quick and decisive decisions. He played in that system like he had been playing in it for three years already. That was impressive about him. The likelihood of him regressing is probably very small."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	7	Tre' Griffiths* (So.)	3	Carson Brown* (Sr.)
WR	5	POFELE ASHLOCK (SR.)	18	Blaze Kamoku (Sr.)
WR	2	Audric Harris* (Jr.)	8	Tama Uiliata (So.)
WR	17	Nick Delgadillo (Jr.)	4	Jarvis Heimuli (So.)
LT	56	Boogie Henderson (So.)	75	Khalil Walker* (Jr.)
LG	62	Lautaimi Manuma (So.)	58	Denaris DeRosa Jr.* (Sr.)
C	57	ETHAN SPENCER (SR.)	50	Tu'i Muti (So.)
RG	79	Judah Kaio (Sr.)	73	Lipe Moala* (Jr.)
RT	52	DEAN BRISKI (SR.)	75	Khalil Walker* (Jr.)
QB	12	MICAH ALEJADO (SO.)	10	Bjorn Jurgensen* (Fr.)
RB	0	Cam Barfield (Sr.)	1	DeVon Rice* (So.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	51	LESTERLAISENE LAGAFUAINA (JR.)	56	Spencer Elliott* (Sr.)
NT	95	Geoffrey Speight* (Sr.)	91	Josh Sagapolutele (Jr.)
DT	52	Luther McCoy (Sr.)	97	Jordan Lynch (So.)
DE	10	Ka'eo Akana (Sr.)	5	Ha'aeo Dela Cruz (So.)
LB	12	Wynden Ho'ohuli (Sr.)	42	Matteus Ioane (So.)
LB	11	JAMIH OTIS (SR.)	12	Matteus Ioane (So.)
CB	1	Caleb Brown* (Sr.)	6	Zion Allen (Sr.)
CB	0	Jeremiah Hughes* (Sr.)	13	Elijah Gipson (Sr.)
NB	4	ELIJAH PALMER (SR.)	21	Makana Meyer (Jr.)
S	25	Matagi Thompson (Sr.)	3	Joel Figueroa* (Sr.)
S	2	Kona Moore (Sr.)	24	Kodi DeCambrá* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	98	Sean Olvera-Harle (Sr.)	KR	0	Cam Barfield (Sr.)
P	47	Gehrig Heil* (Fr.)	PR	8	Tama Uiliata (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN **BOLD** • *2026 TRANSFER



HAWAI'I RAINBOW WARRIORS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 77 | MWC PREDICTION: 3 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 5-3 MWC

OFFENSE It all starts with quarterback Micah Alejado, who is coming off a season in which he earned Mountain West Freshman of the Year honors. He averaged 282.4 passing yards per game and completed 66% of his passes in head coach Timmy Chang's four-wide, spread attack. Alejado had 24 touchdown passes and nine interceptions and also rushed for a score. His quick decision-making and understanding of where to go with the ball were critical for an offense that was eighth nationally in passing.

The two slot receivers look strong once again. Pofele Ashlock is a fourth-year starter who has averaged 73 catches and 763 yards in his first three seasons. Joining him is Washington transfer Audric Harris, who had limited production with the Huskies but looks ready to break out in this offense. The outside receivers are lesser-known quantities.

Cam Barfield moves into the RB1 role after seeing significant action in 2025 with 80 carries for 371 yards, 27 catches for 257 yards and eight total touchdowns. Kansas State transfer DeVon Rice will back him up.

The offensive line welcomes back center Ethan Spencer and right tackle Dean Briski as starters, and Denaris DeRosa Jr. is a highly regarded transfer from San José State.

DEFENSE Hawai'i has only three starters back on a unit that ranked sixth in the conference in total defense. Gone are two all-league players on the defensive line, leaving athletic junior end Lesterlaisene Lagafuaina as the clear leader up front. He had eight tackles for a loss last season.

At linebacker, senior Jamih Otis was an honorable mention All-Mountain West selection last season but tore his ACL in November. He is a leader on defense, but it is unclear if and when he will be able to return. Senior Wynden Ho'ohuli will be the unit's top player until Otis' return.

The defensive backs have depth and some playing experience despite returning only one starter. Elijah Palmer was an honorable mention All-MWC pick and will be starting for his fourth season at nickelback. Caleb Brown returns to Hawai'i after one year at Virginia Tech, and Matagi Thompson started three games at safety.

SPECIALISTS Sean Olvera-Harle will replace All-America placekicker Kansei Matsuzawa after serving as the kickoff specialist last season. Texas transfer Gehrig Heil is battling for the punter spot. Barfield was second-team All-MWC as a return specialist.

FINAL ANALYSIS Hawai'i is a legit threat to win the conference if its defense can come around. Alejado's experience is a huge plus, and he has skilled playmakers. Hawai'i hosts three other contenders — UNLV, New Mexico and North Dakota State — which could prove to be the difference.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 5-3 MWC)

Aug. 23	Stanford	W	23-20
Aug. 30	at Arizona	L	6-40
Sept. 6	Sam Houston	W	37-20
Sept. 13	Portland State	W	23-3
Sept. 20	Fresno State	L	21-23
Sept. 27	at Air Force	W	44-35
Oct. 11	Utah State	W	44-26
Oct. 18	at Colorado State	W	31-19
Nov. 1	at San José State	L	38-45
Nov. 8	San Diego State	W	38-6
Nov. 21	at UNLV	L	10-38
Nov. 29	Wyoming	W	27-7
Dec. 24	vs. Cal #	W	35-31

#Hawai'i Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Aug. 29	at Stanford
Sept. 5	UNLV
Sept. 12	New Mexico State
Sept. 26	at Wyoming
Oct. 3	San José State
Oct. 10	at Arizona State
Oct. 17	New Mexico
Oct. 24	at Northern Illinois
Nov. 7	at UTEP
Nov. 14	North Dakota State
Nov. 21	at Nevada
Nov. 28	Sacramento State

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Andrew Price, OT	★★★
2. Robert Haynes IV, WR	★★★
3. Kydel Stone, CB	★★★
4. Jahren Altura, CB	★★★
5. Maika Eugenio, QB	★★★
6. Christian Sanford-Tupuola, TE	★★★
7. Marquis Richardson, S	★★★
8. Isaiah Nickels, WR	★★★
9. Cooper Troy, IOL	★★★
10. Vainuupo Fanuana, TE	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Timmy Chang • Record at School: 22-29 (4 years)
Career Record: 22-29 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Anthony Arceneaux
Defensive Coordinator: Dennis Thurman • Location: Honolulu, Hawai'i
Stadium: Clarence T. C. Ching Athletics Complex (15,194)



NEVADA WOLF PACK

NATIONAL FORECAST: 113 | MWC PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 2-6 MWC

OFFENSE There is plenty of room for improvement for the Nevada offense, and that starts at quarterback. Wolf Pack QBs, including this year's projected starter, Carter Jones, threw 10 TDs and 17 INTs last season, which was the worst ratio in the country. Jones was a true freshman forced into action earlier than the staff would have liked, but he is making strides as he tries to hold off UCLA transfer Luke Duncan for the No. 1 job in new offensive coordinator Brett Bartolone's system.

Herschel Turner figures to earn the No. 1 running back job after averaging 5.1 yards per carry last season. Dominic Kelley flashed as a freshman power back.

Nevada lost its top five receivers from last season, so transfers will play key roles. The Wolf Pack will lean heavily on senior Damien Morgan, who was productive at FCS Idaho State. Gary Givens III comes in from Northern Illinois after limited production. Marshaun Brown is the leading returner with 16 catches last season.

The offensive line returns two starters and brought in some impact transfers, so this group could set a foundation for the offense.

DEFENSE Nevada has a chance to be solid on defense thanks to the return of a potential All-Mountain West player at each level. Defensive end Dylan LaBarbera will be a candidate for MWC Defensive Player of the Year and looks to have an NFL future after recording a league-best 17 tackles for a loss. Defensive tackle Logologo Va'a also returns.

At linebacker, EJ Smith missed the second half of last season due to injury but had become one of the team's leaders and should have a big year. Colorado State transfer Jeremy Naborne-Owens saw significant action with the Rams last season.

In the secondary, cornerback Aiden Walker emerged during his true freshman season and projects as the team's top player along the back line. At the other corner, Bryson Snelling has starting experience, and starting safety Bishop Turner also returns.

SPECIALISTS Senior placekicker Joe McFadden was 19-for-25 on field goals last season, with a long of 50 yards. There will be a new Australian punter for the Wolf Pack as Ewan Baulch and Jacob Fernandez are coming to the U.S. to vie for the job.

FINAL ANALYSIS Nevada's four-year bowl drought is the program's longest since 1997-2004, and it may be an uphill climb to end it this season. There are wins to be found on the schedule, but to get to six, a jump forward will be needed in the passing game with either Jones or Duncan at the controls.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 2-6 MWC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 at Penn State L 11-46	Sept. 5 WKU	1. Janerious Jackson, RB ★★★
Sept. 6 Sacramento State W 20-17	Sept. 12 Montana State	2. Colton Hogge, OT ★★★
Sept. 13 Middle Tennessee L 13-14	Sept. 19 at Middle Tenn.	3. Joe Stimpson, WR ★★★
Sept. 20 at WKU L 16-31	Sept. 26 Air Force	4. Perrion Williams, WR ★★★
Oct. 4 at Fresno State L 17-20	Oct. 10 at UTEP	5. Isaiah Williams, WR ★★★
Oct. 11 San Diego State L 10-44	Oct. 17 at North Dakota St.	6. Mekai Smith, RB ★★★
Oct. 18 at New Mexico L 22-24	Oct. 24 San José State	7. Bronwyn Rios, RB ★★★
Oct. 24 Boise State L 3-24	Oct. 31 at UCLA	8. Sam Davidson IV, EDGE ★★★
Nov. 8 at Utah State L 14-51	Nov. 7 New Mexico	9. Terrence Johnson, OT ★★★
Nov. 15 San José State W 55-10	Nov. 14 at Northern Illinois	10. CJ Mooring, RB ★★★
Nov. 22 at Wyoming W 13-7	Nov. 21 Hawai'i	
Nov. 29 UNLV L 17-42	Nov. 28 at UNLV	

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION	
Head Coach: Jeff Choate • Record at School: 6-19 (2 years) • Career Record: 34-41 (6 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Brett Bartolone • Defensive Coordinator: Kane Ioane • Location: Reno, Nev. • Stadium: Mackay Stadium (27,000)	



CARTER JONES

SCOUTING THE WOLF PACK

"They're a team that lost a ton in the portal both offensively and defensively. They do return their best pass-rusher [Dylan LaBarbera]. That dude is damn good. We called him 'Captain Insano' when we played him last year. That dude's a stud. We couldn't block the guy. They return him and [quarterback] Carter Jones, who finished out the year. ... I think they're gonna be fine. They're gonna be very young still, just based on what they signed. They brought in a couple of receivers that had some production, but what they lost is still gonna be hard to replace. I think that they'll be very similar to last year."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	11	Damien Morgan* (Sr.)	85	Donnie Cheers* (Jr.)
WR	7	Gary Givens III* (Jr.)	3	Jaceon Doss* (Sr.)
WR	9	Marshaun Brown (Jr.)	8	Dajion Calimon (So.)
LT	55	JACK FOSTER (SR.)	67	RJ Esmon (Jr.)
LG	70	Snoop Leota-Amaama (Sr.)	72	Ethan Newman (Jr.)
C	59	Jacob Norcross* (Jr.)	58	Ethan Lowell (So.)
RG	72	Ethan Newman* (Jr.)	70	Snoop Leota-Amaama (Sr.)
RT	76	ZACH COCHNAUER (SR.)	73	Tyler Miller (So.)
TE	16	DJ Asiati (Fr.)	82	Jayden O'Rourke (Sr.)
QB	6	CARTER JONES (SO.)	12	Luke Duncan* (Jr.)
RB	1	Herschel Turner (Jr.)	0	Dominic Kelley (So.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	32	DYLAN LABARBERA (SR.)	3	Kameron Brown (Fr.)
DT	10	Logologo Va'a (Sr.)	98	David Paine Jr. (So.)
DT	96	Tanner Vaughan (Sr.)	98	David Paine Jr. (So.)
DE	92	Myles Williams (Sr.)	4	Brandon Amaniampong* (Jr.)
LB	2	EJ SMITH (SR.)	11	Poasa Utu* (Jr.)
LB	1	Jeremy Naborne-Owens* (Sr.)	44	Alosio Maluia (So.)
CB	18	Aiden Walker (So.)	0	Joshua Scott* (Sr.)
CB	12	Bryson Snelling (Jr.)	0	Joshua Scott* (Sr.)
NB	0	Joshua Scott* (Sr.)	7	Selman Bridges* (So.)
S	15	Bishop Turner (Jr.)	22	Jaylen Webb* (Jr.)
S	8	Larry Turner-Gooden* (Sr.)	22	Jaylen Webb* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	84	Joe McFadden (Sr.)	KR	25	Ky Woods (Sr.)
P	95	Ewan Baulch (Fr.)	PR	14	Gerick Robinson (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

ANDY BARRON



JACK LAYNE

SCOUTING THE LOBOS

"[Head coach] Jason Eck definitely has a great program. He's a successful head coach going back to his Idaho days. His son [linebacker Jaxton Eck] is what makes their defense go. He is truly the heartbeat of that defense. I know their defensive coordinator [Spence Nowinsky] is a really good coach with a really good scheme. I don't know that they would ever be the Group of 6 team in the playoff, but they can definitely be a team that gets to a good bowl game. ... I don't think Eck will be there long. Our staff thinks that when Luke Fickell gets let go at Wisconsin, that's Eck's job if he does what he's supposed to do this year. They're a sleeper to win the league."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (7)

WR	5	Troy Omeire* (Sr.)	6	Zhaiel Smith (So.)
WR	0	Miles Williams* (Sr.)	11	Massiah Mingo (Fr.)
WR	1	SHAWN MILLER (SR.)	14	DJ Darling (Fr.)
LT	79	Cole Millward (Jr.)	55	Elvin Harris (Sr.)
LG	51	MALIK ALIANE (SR.)	77	Tevin Shaw (Sr.)
C	59	KADEN ROBBETT (SO.)	54	JoJo Matautia (Fr.)
RG	58	JAYMAR TASI (SO.)	77	Tevin Shaw (Sr.)
RT	68	TYLER LAWRENCE (JR.)	55	Elvin Harris (Jr.)
TE	88	CADE KEITH (SO.)	7	Tripp Walsh (Jr.)
QB	2	JACK LAYNE (SR.)	10	Luke Moga* (So.)
RB	22	Scottre Humphrey (Sr.)	8	Deshaun Buchanan (Jr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	10	Darren Agu (Sr.)	32	Trent Rocker (Jr.)
DT	15	Xavier Slayton (Sr.)	92	BRIAN BOOKER (SR.)
DT	94	Jalen McIver (Jr.)	88	AJ Robinson (Jr.)
DE	22	Jalen Charles* (So.)	36	Albert Tuakalau* (Jr.)
LB	6	JAXTON ECK (JR.)	18	Clay Martineau* (So.)
LB	2	MERCURY SWAIM (SR.)	23	Nick Wheeler (Fr.)
CB	5	Frankie Edwards III (Jr.)	9	Eric McClain* (Jr.)
CB	8	Ormanie Arnold* (Sr.)	1	Jahmir Torres (So.)
NB	13	Chris Gant Jr. (So.)	17	Will Hicks* (Jr.)
S	7	TAVIAN COMBS (SR.)	3	CJ McBEAN (SO.)
S	0	Austin Brawley (Sr.)	12	Drew Speech (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	41	Nick Romero* (So.)	KR	2	Abraham Williams (Sr.)
P	35	Charles Steinkamp (Sr.)	PR	0	Austin Brawley (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



NEW MEXICO LOBOS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 61 | MWC PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-2 MWC

OFFENSE Starting quarterback Jack Layne is back after completing 65% of his passes and averaging 191 yards per game with 13 TDs and 10 interceptions. Layne was a limited participant in spring drills, and he may have competition in the fall from Oregon transfer Luke Moga. The former 4-star prospect left the Ducks when Dante Moore returned to school.

A pair of transfers could be the team's top two pass-catchers. Troy Omeire, who has played at Texas, Arizona State and UNLV, had 31 catches for 514 yards and five TDs for the Rebels last year. Miles Williams comes in from FCS Eastern Washington and is expected to be a heavy lifter in the passing game. Cade Keith will be an All-Mountain West candidate in an offense that emphasizes the tight end.

The running back room is deep, with Scottre Humphrey the leading returning rusher with 349 yards. Humphrey got off to a fast start but never quite recovered from an injury in Week 3. Cameron Mathews comes in after a redshirt year at Memphis.

The offensive line returns four starters but still has a few question marks. Center Kaden Robnett is an All-MWC candidate.

DEFENSE This unit has the potential to be the league's best. MWC Defensive Player of the Year Jaxton Eck averaged nearly 10 tackles per game from his linebacker spot. He is joined by Mercury Swaim, who emerged late last year and is an All-MWC candidate as well in the middle of the defense. The Lobos led the league in rushing defense last season.

Up front, former FCS Idaho transfer Xavier Slayton beat out Brian Booker, who was an honorable mention All-MWC pick at defensive tackle. Former Vanderbilt transfer Darren Agu is in for a big season in his second year at New Mexico.

Tavian Combs, CJ McBean and Austin Brawley were all productive at safety last year and earned starting assignments. Cornerback Ormanie Arnold is a transfer from Cincinnati who will get immediate playing time.

SPECIALISTS Abraham Williams returned five kickoffs for touchdowns at FCS Weber State in 2022 and '23 and had six total returns last year in his first season at New Mexico. Charles Steinkamp will be the punter after serving as the kickoff specialist the past two seasons. There will be a three-way kicker battle in fall camp.

FINAL ANALYSIS Head coach Jason Eck worked wonders last season in winning nine games in Year 1, and the Lobos are among the league favorites this season. The defense will be among the best in the MWC, and if the offensive line jells and one of the two quarterbacks emerges, the Lobos will appear in their first Mountain West Championship Game.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-2 MWC)

Aug. 30	at Michigan	L	17-34
Sept. 6	Idaho State	W	32-22
Sept. 12	at UCLA	W	35-10
Sept. 27	New Mexico State	W	38-20
Oct. 3	at San José State	L	28-35
Oct. 11	at Boise State	L	25-41
Oct. 18	Nevada	W	24-22
Oct. 25	Utah State	W	33-14
Nov. 1	at UNLV	W	40-35
Nov. 15	Colorado State	W	20-17
Nov. 22	at Air Force	W	20-3
Nov. 28	San Diego State (ot)	W	23-17
Dec. 26	vs. Minnesota # (ot)	L	17-20

#Rate Bowl

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	Central Michigan
Sept. 12	Mercyhurst
Sept. 19	at Oklahoma
Sept. 26	at New Mexico St.
Oct. 3	UTEP
Oct. 17	at Hawai'i
Oct. 24	North Dakota State
Oct. 31	at San José State
Nov. 7	at Nevada
Nov. 14	UNLV
Nov. 21	at Wyoming
Nov. 28	Air Force

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Cade Mitchell, QB	★★★★
2.	DJ Darling, WR	★★★
3.	Brody Litton, OT	★★★
4.	Jvon Hatcher, DL	★★★
5.	Jaron Liles, WR	★★★
6.	Massiah Mingo, WR	★★★
7.	Max Leeper, TE	★★★
8.	Ricklan Holmes II, LB	★★★
9.	Brendan Alexander, IOL	★★★
10.	Albert Tuakalau, EDGE	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Jason Eck • Record at School: 9-4 (1 year)
Career Record: 35-17 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Luke Schleusner
Defensive Coordinator: Spence Nowinsky • Location: Albuquerque, N.M.
Stadium: University Stadium (39,224)



NORTH DAKOTA STATE BISON

NATIONAL FORECAST: 78 | MWC PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 12-1, 8-0 MVFC

OFFENSE Senior quarterback Nathan Hayes will take the reins after being QB2 on last season's 12-1 team that lost a heartbreaker in the second round of the FCS playoffs. Hayes saw limited action in 10 games last season, but he will now be responsible for directing the offense as it moves up a level to the FBS Mountain West Conference. Hayes is a running threat and has good speed and a strong arm at 6-foot-3, 218 pounds.

Three starters are back along the offensive line, and Kansas transfer Kene Anene looks like an immediate fit at right tackle. Head coach Tim Polasek, who is entering his third season, should be able to rely on this group.

The skill positions have some unknowns. Running back DJ Scott averaged 7.3 carries per game last year and finished the year with 502 yards, and he will likely try to double those numbers as the lead back for 2026. Redshirt freshman Myles Mitchell will have a larger role as well, and incoming freshman Braylon Toliver could earn serious playing time.

Tight end Reis Kessel returns after averaging an impressive 22.3 yards per catch last season. The leading wideout is Jackson Williams, who started two games and had 293 receiving yards for the season. Young players will need to step up.

DEFENSE The Bison lost defensive captain and linebacker Nathaniel Staehling on the final day of the portal period to Michigan, weakening what looked like a stellar linebacking corps. All-conference junior Donovan Woolen is back, but there will be inexperience around him. Freshman Gavin Sell will get a long look.

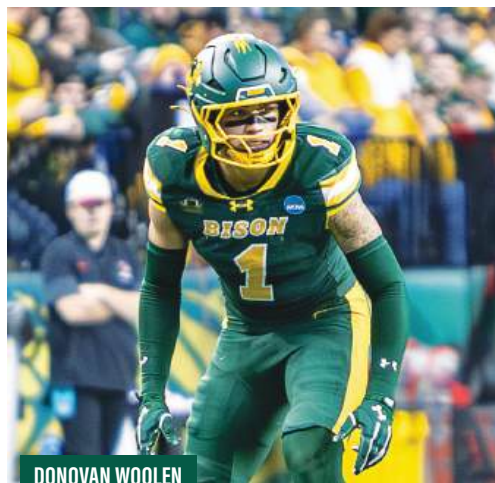
Starting safeties Darius Givance and Taylen Eady have solid depth behind them. At cornerback, there are questions. Two Division II transfers arrive to help replace both starters who transferred, and there are four players at the position who were depth pieces a year ago.

On the line, all-conference performer Keenan Wilson leads the group from his defensive tackle spot.

SPECIALISTS Drew Klein takes over the placekicking duties after making his only attempt from 46 yards a year ago. Punter Aaron Bickerton is back after averaging 45.4 yards per boot in 2025.

FINAL ANALYSIS It will not be a surprise to see North Dakota State elevate and make the adjustment to the Mountain West given its long history of success. The respective lines are usually a concern when you step up a level, but NDSU should be fine there. If some wide receivers develop for Hayes, and some defensive backs emerge, the Bison could be a fringe contender in the MWC in Year 1.

2025 RESULTS (12-1, 8-0 FCS MVFC)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 at The Citadel W 38-0	Aug. 29 Jacksonville State	1. Braylon Toliver, RB ★★ ★
Sept. 6 at Tennessee State W 59-3	Sept. 5 Fordham	2. Gunner Thielges, S ★★ ★
Sept. 13 SE Missouri State W 41-14	Sept. 12 at Air Force	3. Kye Schlichting, WR ★★ ★
Sept. 27 South Dakota W 51-13	Sept. 19 at Sacramento St.	4. Joaquin Jordan, WR ★★ ★
Oct. 4 at Illinois State W 33-16	Oct. 3 Wyoming	5. Hank Nelson, QB ★★ ★
Oct. 11 Southern Illinois W 45-17	Oct. 10 at UNLV	6. Trey McPartland, OT ★★ ★
Oct. 18 at Indiana State W 38-7	Oct. 17 Nevada	7. Myles Ellis, WR ★★ ★
Oct. 25 at South Dakota State W 38-7	Oct. 24 at New Mexico	8. Tucker Thieneman, OT ★★ ★
Nov. 1 Youngstown State W 38-30	Oct. 31 UTEP	9. Jason Hunter Jr., DL ★★ ★
Nov. 8 at North Dakota W 15-10	Nov. 14 at Hawai'i	10. Brandon Walton, S ★★ ★
Nov. 15 Northern Iowa W 48-16	Nov. 21 Northern Illinois	
Nov. 22 St. Thomas (MN) W 62-7	Nov. 28 at San José State	
Dec. 6 Illinois State # L 28-29		
#FCS Playoff Second Round		*Per Rivals
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Tim Polasek • Record at School: 26-3 (2 years)		
Career Record: 26-3 (2 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Dan Larson		
Defensive Coordinator: Grant Olson • Location: Fargo, N.D.		
Stadium: Fargodome (18,700)		



DONOVAN WOOLEN

SCOUTING THE BISON

"That transition is not going to be as [difficult] as maybe people outside the sport think it's gonna be. All the coaches who are in the know, they know who North Dakota State is. I think those guys are going to be contending in the Mountain West. They moved up and paid all that money because they felt good about where they are from a talent standpoint. I just don't think you make that move if you look at your roster and go, 'Man, I don't know how good we are.' ... You look at the amount of guys that they've put in the NFL, they have a confidence in how they develop. Yeah, they lost their quarterback and top receiver, but the rest of us don't know who they have behind them. They do, and they feel very confident in the guys they have."

—An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	18	Jackson Williams (Jr.)	83	Cade Osterman (Jr.)
WR	15	Mekhi Collins (Sr.)	84	Logan Conklin (So.)
WR	17	Isiah St. Romain (So.)	21	Chris Kiel (Fr.)
LT	76	Ryan Babatz (So.)	57	Gavin Wang (Fr.)
LG	71	NATE TASTAD (SO.)	66	Jack Liwienski (Jr.)
C	62	GRIFFIN EMPEY (JR.)	61	Gage Schmidt (So.)
RG	75	JOSH MAGIN (SR.)	72	Nate Schneckloth (Jr.)
RT	55	Kene Anene* (So.)	78	Noah Stommes (So.)
TE	81	Reis Kessel (So.)	40	Kaden Zenzen (Sr.)
QB	2	Nathan Hayes (Sr.)	10	Trey Drake (Jr.)
RB	7	DJ Scott (Jr.)	5	Myles Mitchell (Fr.)

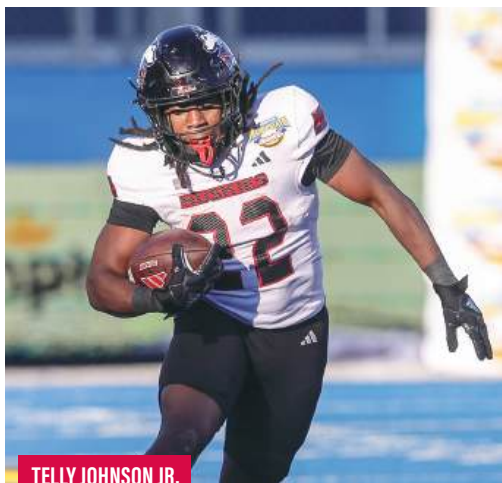
DEFENSE (5)

DE	11	Matthew Stenbroten (So.)	0	Victor Isele (Jr.)
DT	8	KEENAN WILSON (JR.)	54	Alijah Wayne (So.)
DT	94	Logan Larson (Sr.)	95	Zach Vanderpool (So.)
DE	9	KELTON MCCASLIN (SR.)	93	Anthony Okes* (Jr.)
LB	1	DONOVAN WOOLEN (JR.)	41	Peder Haugo (So.)
LB	52	Keith Williams* (Jr.)	55	Oliver Lucht (Jr.)
LB	3	Gavin Sell (Fr.)	50	Damian Devine (Fr.)
CB	2	EJ Davis* (So.)	16	Marion Moore (Fr.)
CB	12	DJ Voltz* (Sr.)	4	Najee Nelson (Jr.)
S	29	DARIUS GIVANCE (SR.)	6	JAYLIN CRUMBY (JR.)
S	14	Taylen Eady (So.)	20	Will Steil (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	37	Drew Klein (Sr.)	KR	18	Jackson Williams (Jr.)
P	39	Aaron Bickerton (Sr.)	PR	18	Jackson Williams (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



TELLY JOHNSON JR.

SCOUTING THE HUSKIES

"That's the state of college football with a lot more coaches [like ex-NIU head coach Thomas Hammock] leaving to take NFL opportunities. The G6 level presents a lot of challenges. I think if you want to just coach football, being a head coach at the G6 level is probably not the best place because you are wearing so many different hats. ... Schematically, they'll have a little adjustment to the Mountain West because there are more spread-out offenses than there are in the MAC. There are some pretty wild elevation places, and that's different. They're coming from a league where most teams want to run the ball, and in the Mountain West, you've got more [pass-first teams]. But they've got good coaches over there, so they'll figure it out and adapt."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	1	DEAREE ROGERS (SR.)	7	Cam Thompson* (Sr.)
WR	13	Kevin Holmes Jr.* (Jr.)	0	La'Don Bryant (So.)
WR	3	Rickey Taylor Jr. (So.)	12	Tavaris Coles* (Jr.)
LT	5	ROSS LIEGEL (SO.)	61	Ben Gustafson (So.)
LG	53	Luke Skartvedt (Jr.)	62	Grey Rumohr (So.)
C	63	LANDON HRON (JR.)	69	Logan Gross (So.)
RG	55	Ty Mead* (Sr.)	68	Samir Senenat (So.)
RT	66	Lane Mahnesmith (So.)	78	Jacob Welch (Jr.)
TE	83	Jason Fowler (So.)	85	Joe Stein (So.)
QB	2	Brady Davidson (So.)	14	Jalen Macon (Sr.)
RB	45	TELLY JOHNSON JR. (JR.)	24	Elijah Porter (So.)

DEFENSE (0)

DE	18	Jay'shon Thomas (Jr.)	19	James Bradley* (Jr.)
DT	92	Jacob McGhee* (Jr.)	50	Matthew Scarlett (Jr.)
DT	11	Amari Washington (Fr.)	0	Montrel Canion (Fr.)
DE	56	Joseph Nnamuchi* (Jr.)	13	Mathias Smith-Davis* (So.)
MLB	8	Cooper Mau* (Jr.)	6	Kimar Nelson (Fr.)
WLB	15	Broderick Windham (Sr.)	25	Brady Kerperin* (So.)
CB	9	Dev'ion Reynolds (So.)	20	Marshall Washington* (Jr.)
CB	5	Yassine Falke* (Jr.)	3	Liam Lindo* (Sr.)
NB	12	Aaron Warren* (Sr.)	17	Avery Jones* (Sr.)
S	7	Justin Harris* (Jr.)	14	Malik Armstrong (Sr.)
S	26	Tyrese Stanley* (Jr.)	16	Kyon Conyers* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	33	JJ Schlenhardt (Fr.)	KR	9	Dev'ion Reynolds (So.)
P	36	Jake Ference (So.)	PR	1	DeAree Rogers (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



NORTHERN ILLINOIS HUSKIES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 134 | MWC PREDICTION: 10 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 2-6 MAC

OFFENSE The Huskies have a choice to make at quarterback that will influence their offensive philosophy, which needs an overhaul after NIU finished 132nd nationally in total offense in 2025. Sophomore Brady Davidson had two starts; senior Jalen Macon closed last season as the starter; and transfer Ean Hamric arrives from Div. II University of Charleston.

Davidson is a traditional pocket passer who averaged 27 passes in his two starts as a true freshman. Macon is a run-first athlete who is explosive with the ball in his hands but did not get the opportunity to throw many passes. And Hamric is a dual-threat who averaged 155 passing yards and 61 rushing yards per game while leading his team to a league title.

The top running back will be Telly Johnson Jr. He averaged 5.7 yards per carry last year, ranking second in the MAC. Included in that was an 80-yard run against Eastern Michigan.

DeAree Rogers (46 receptions, 506 yards) is the No. 1 target in the passing game. Rickey Taylor Jr. is another weapon who missed half of last season due to injury, but he averaged a team-best 14.9 yards per reception.

The offensive line will be young, with center Landon Hron and left tackle Ross Liegel the only experienced starters.

DEFENSE The secondary enters the season as the best position group on the team. Justin Harris and Tyrese Stanley are a couple of junior-college transfers who should comprise a solid safety tandem. Dev'ion Reynolds will man one corner, and transfer Yassine Falke from NAIA Marian was all-conference and is expected to make an impact.

In NIU's 4-2-5 scheme, Broderick Windham is moving from safety to linebacker, and Cooper Mau will try to hold off Kimar Nelson, who came on strong toward the end of his true freshman season and should be a key factor in a defense that finished eighth in the MAC last season.

The defensive line will be counting on Amari Washington and Jacob McGhee, a transfer from Div. II Lincoln (Mo.) University, to step up. Washington, a defensive tackle, made significant progress last year and has coaches excited.

SPECIALISTS Jake Ference is back after sharing punting duties last year and averaging 43.7 yards per kick. Rogers and Reynolds should again handle punt return and kick return duties, respectively.

FINAL ANALYSIS Northern Illinois, which limped through a 3-9 season last year, is moving to the Mountain West Conference and will go through the year with interim head coach Rob Harley after Thomas Hammock left in February to join the Seattle Seahawks staff. With questions at quarterback and youth along both lines, it projects to be a difficult season for the Huskies in their new conference.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 2-6 MAC)

Aug. 30	Holy Cross	W	19-17
Sept. 5	at Maryland	L	9-20
Sept. 20	at Mississippi State	L	10-38
Sept. 27	San Diego State	L	3-6
Oct. 4	Miami (Ohio)	L	14-25
Oct. 11	at Eastern Michigan	L	10-16
Oct. 18	at Ohio	L	21-48
Oct. 25	Ball State	W	21-7
Nov. 5	at Toledo	L	3-42
Nov. 12	at UMass	W	45-3
Nov. 18	Western Michigan	L	19-35
Nov. 28	Kent State	L	31-35

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at Iowa
Sept. 12	Illinois State
Sept. 19	at Arizona
Sept. 26	at Georgia State
Oct. 10	Air Force
Oct. 17	at Wyoming
Oct. 24	Hawai'i
Oct. 31	at UNLV
Nov. 7	at San José State
Nov. 14	Nevada
Nov. 21	at North Dakota St.
Nov. 28	UTEP

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1.	Bryshaw Brown, QB	★★★
2.	Ross Ogden, LB	★★★
3.	Braylon Agee, WR	★★★
4.	Deacon King, S	★★★
5.	Asa Johnson, QB	★★★
6.	Jaiduan Cranford, RB	★★★
7.	Jack Murray, LB	★★★
8.	Cian Mahoney, IOL	★★★
9.	Jermaine Green, WR	★★★
10.	Darrius Summers III, EDGE	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Rob Harley • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinators: Tony Petersen, Quinn Sanders • Defensive Coordinator: Rob Harley • Location: DeKalb, Ill. • Stadium: Huskie Stadium (28,211)



SAN JOSÉ STATE SPARTANS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 116 | MWC PREDICTION: 8 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 2-6 MWC

OFFENSE The Spartans were second in the Mountain West in passing offense a year ago but were undone by 17 interceptions. Whoever wins the QB battle between last year's third-stringer Robert McDaniel, Hawai'i transfer Luke Weaver and freshman Daniel Rolovich will need to take better care of the football. McDaniel was the leader during spring practice.

The wide receiver room, which has produced the nation's leader in receiving yardage (Danny Scudero in 2025 and Nick Nash in 2024) in both of head coach Ken Niumatalolo's first two seasons, will be starting from scratch. Malachi Riley, who was slated to start last season before being lost for the season in Week 1 to a lower-body injury, should be the No. 1 pass-catcher. Penn State transfer Anthony Ivey will also be one to watch.

At running back, Jabari Bates returns and will get the bulk of the carries after averaging a team-best 7.1 yards per rush and just under 50 yards per game as a reserve.

The offensive line allowed a league-low 13 sacks a year ago, but only two starters return. Senior center Joseph Harbert could be in line for all-league honors if he continues to develop.

DEFENSE The Spartans are rebuilding on defense. Ethan Powell is back at outside linebacker, and Zane Carter, who was slated to start but missed 2025 due to injury, should be the starter at the other outside 'backer. On the inside, FCS Weber State transfer Aizik Mahuka made a big impression on the coaching staff early in spring.

The defensive line will look to Justin Stearns to lead the way at end. He has six career starts. Nate Lewis is an athletic end who showed signs of development in the spring.

SJSU's allowed the MWC's second-highest passer rating and tied for a league-low seven interceptions. Corner Greco Carrillo would have started but missed 2025 due to injury. Kejuan Bullard Jr. has also worked his way to the top of the depth chart, and FCS Cal Poly transfer safety Brian Dukes Jr. and converted wideout Tuli Tagovailoa-Amosa will be working with new pass game coordinator/cornerbacks coach Brian Norwood.

SPECIALISTS Punter Trent Carrizosa is an all-league candidate after averaging 45.6 yards per kick last season. The placekicking duties will come down to Mathias Brown, who was 4-for-7 on field goals last year, and FCS Idaho State transfer Trajan Sinatra.

FINAL ANALYSIS The Spartans are starting over after a surprising 3-9 season snapped a three-year run of bowl games. There is a wide variance between SJSU's floor and ceiling. There is a recent track record of an elite pass offense, but the defense is full of questions.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 2-6 MWC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 29	Central Michigan	L	14-16	Aug. 29	at USC	1. Carson Clark, WR	★★★
Sept. 6	at Texas	L	7-38	Sept. 4	at Eastern Michigan	2. Devin Olmande, WR	★★★
Sept. 20	Idaho	W	31-28	Sept. 12	Cal Poly	3. Johnny Notarianni, IOL	★★★
Sept. 27	at Stanford	L	29-30	Sept. 19	Fresno State	4. Daniel Rolovich, QB	★★★
Oct. 3	New Mexico	W	35-28	Oct. 3	at Hawai'i	5. Bronx Letuligasenoa, EDGE	★★★
Oct. 11	at Wyoming	L	28-35	Oct. 10	Wyoming	6. Shane Kiley, TE	★★★
Oct. 17	at Utah State	L	25-30	Oct. 17	at UTEP	7. Skylar Tiatia, LB	★★★
Nov. 1	Hawai'i	W	45-38	Oct. 24	at Nevada	8. Courshaw Hill, RB	★★★
Nov. 8	Air Force	L	16-26	Oct. 31	New Mexico	9. Viliami Lotoaniu, LB	★★★
Nov. 15	at Nevada	L	10-55	Nov. 7	Northern Illinois	10. Keenan Parks, IOL	★★★
Nov. 22	at San Diego State	L	3-25	Nov. 14	at Air Force		
Nov. 29	Fresno State	L	14-41	Nov. 21	UNLV		
				Nov. 28	North Dakota State		

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Ken Niumatalolo • Record at School: 10-15 (2 years) • Career Record: 119-98 (18 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Craig Stutzmann • Defensive Coordinator: Bojay Filimoeatu • Location: San José, Calif. • Stadium: CEFCU Stadium (18,203)



JABARI BATES

SCOUTING THE SPARTANS

"I know they were disappointed with the season they had last year. But that offense is a system, and that offense produces. I know they brought in a new defensive coordinator and some new guys on staff, but [head coach] Ken Niumatalolo is a winner. I would think everyone in the conference would anticipate them being closer to how they were when they went to a bowl game in that first season in 2024. ... I'd be willing to bet that they're gonna have a pretty solid bounce-back year and be a contender, probably more than people outside the conference would think. ... They had [receiver] Danny Scudero last year and the [receiving] triple crown winner, Nick Nash, the year before. They're just great at finding ways to get their playmakers the ball."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	11	Malachi Riley (Jr.)	21	Carson Clark (Fr.)
WR	10	Anthony Ivey* (Sr.)	14	Dominique McKenzie* (So.)
WR	27	Tama Amisone (So.)	13	Cooper Hoch (Jr.)
WR	15	Jerry McClure* (Jr.)	20	Jordan Anderson* (So.)
LT	63	Brian Tapu* (Fr.)	72	Lavaka Taukeiaho* (Sr.)
LG	54	Daniel Moleni (Sr.)	78	David Perez (So.)
C	75	JOSEPH HARBERT (SR.)	77	Daniel Tuliau (Fr.)
RG	62	TYLER CHEN (JR.)	71	Makoni Manukainiu (So.)
RT	56	Simeon Afalava (Sr.)	70	Ikiansio Tupou* (So.)
QB	12	Robert McDaniel (Fr.)	3	Luke Weaver* (Sr.)
RB	6	Jabari Bates (Sr.)	34	Viliami Teu (Jr.)

DEFENSE (0)

DE	57	Justin Stearns (Sr.)	91	Jeremiah Tuileleila* (Fr.)
DT	51	Solomone Langi (Sr.)	90	Jayland McGlothen* (Jr.)
DT	92	Noa Siaoosi (Jr.)	55	Ian Shewell* (Sr.)
DE	99	Nate Lewis (Sr.)	89	Etu Finau (Sr.)
OLB	26	Ethan Powell (Sr.)	18	Dylan Lee (Jr.)
MLB	16	Naseri Danielson (Jr.)	14	Aizik Mahuka* (Jr.)
OLB	25	Zane Carter (Jr.)	24	Malakai Hoeft (Sr.)
CB	5	Kejuan Bullard Jr. (Sr.)	2	Maliki Crawford (Jr.)
CB	12	Greco Carrillo (So.)	23	Isaiah Buxton* (So.)
S	1	Brian Dukes Jr.* (Sr.)	27	Jackson Barton* (So.)
S	39	Tuli Tagovailoa-Amosa (So.)	13	Pierce Walker* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	99	Mathias Brown (Jr.)	KR	6	Jabari Bates (Sr.)
P	49	Trent Carrizosa (Sr.)	PR	39	Tuli Tagovailoa-Amosa (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



JAI'DEN THOMAS

SCOUTING THE REBELS

"[Head coach] Dan Mullen still has his fastball. No doubt about it. Their quarterback last year [Anthony Colandrea], he was like [former Vanderbilt QB] Diego Pavia with how he ran around and the off-schedule stuff. It was crazy. It was like he was covered in grease. He was special. It might look a little different [with him transferring to Nebraska], but they're reloading. We're gonna have to learn how to try to defend that in the same way. You've got two guys in [Alex] Orji and [Auburn transfer] Jackson Arnold who were former blue-chip recruits who are battling it out to be the starter. Their running back [Jai'Den Thomas] was the best back in the league last year. He decided to stay for a reason. ... They're gonna be the betting favorites to win the league."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	16	Kayden McGee (So.)	80	Taz Reddicks* (Jr.)
WR	8	Taashaun Lyons (Jr.)	17	Amorion Walker* (Sr.)
WR	4	DeAngelo Irvin Jr. (Sr.)	87	Tavian McNair (Fr.)
LT	72	WILL THOMAS (SR.)	63	Alekai Afoa (Jr.)
LG	77	Colton Thomasson* (Jr.)	65	Ace Robinson (Fr.)
C	79	AUSTIN BOYD (SR.)	66	BJ Tolo* (Jr.)
RG	55	Griffin Scroggs* (Sr.)	74	Amare Taase (So.)
RT	78	Jackson Brown* (Jr.)	73	Jesus Garcia II (Fr.)
TE	84	Keyan Burnett* (Sr.)	88	Velltray Jefferson (Sr.)
QB	11	Jackson Arnold* (Sr.)	1	Alex Orji (Sr.)
RB	9	JAI'DEN THOMAS (SR.)	20	Jaylon Glover (Sr.)

DEFENSE (3)

DE	42	Andre Porter (So.)	91	Elias Rudolph (So.)
DT	94	LUCAS CONTI (JR.)	90	Elijah Logo (Fr.)
DT	16	Mohamed Altayeb (Sr.)	88	Mo Abbasher (Jr.)
DE	18	Landen Thomas (Jr.)	32	Kenji Scanlan (So.)
LB	15	BLESYNG ALUALU-TUIOLEMOTU (JR.)	30	Dee Crayton* (Sr.)
LB	43	Kamuela Ka'aihue (Sr.)	34	Cam Santee* (Sr.)
CB	2	Denver Harris (Sr.)	25	Jaylen Allen (So.)
CB	5	Quandarius Keyes (Sr.)	6	Mumu Bin-Wahad (Sr.)
NB	22	Kyron Chambers* (Sr.)	20	Landyn Cleveland* (Jr.)
S	7	JAKE POPE (SR.)	28	Logan Christensen (So.)
S	10	Tre Fulton (So.)	24	Tony-Louis Nkuba* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	32	Ramon Villela (Jr.)	KR	4	DeAngelo Irvin Jr. (Sr.)
P	4	Matt Choules* (Fr.)	PR	4	DeAngelo Irvin Jr. (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



UNLV REBELS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 59 | MWC PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 10-4, 6-2 MWC

OFFENSE Auburn transfer quarterback Jackson Arnold is hoping that he experiences what Anthony Colandrea did in his one year at UNLV. Colandrea was the Mountain West Offensive Player of the Year in head coach Dan Mullen's first season, and Arnold will try to pick up where Colandrea left off. Arnold has starting experience at Oklahoma and Auburn, but he ultimately lost his job at both schools. If he loses his job at UNLV, former Michigan transfer Alex Orji is the backup as a run-first option.

Jai'Den "Jet" Thomas will be a fourth-year starter after rushing for 1,036 yards and 12 TDs last season. He is the face of the program and will be a candidate for MWC Offensive Player of the Year.

The wide receiver room has no starters returning, but the coaches are excited about sophomore Kayden McGee. He made big plays on special teams last season, scoring the winning TD against Utah State, and he is the team's fastest player. Taashaun Lyons was productive last season in a reserve role.

All-conference lineman Austin Boyd is moving from tackle to center, and starting left tackle Will Thomas also returns.

DEFENSE One starter returns at each level for a defense that ranked 89th in the nation in scoring. Blesyng Alualu-Tuiotomoti emerged late last season at linebacker and will be a cornerstone. Linebacker transfer Cam Santee was the CAA Defensive Player of the Year at FCS Holy Cross last year and will be in the rotation with starter Kamuela Ka'aihue.

Up front, junior Lucas Conti returns for his fourth season and will anchor the line. Andre Porter and Landen Thomas will move into more prominent roles on the ends.

In the secondary, Jake Pope spent two years at Alabama and one at Georgia before starting all 14 games last year for UNLV. He will be the leader of a much-improved backline. Kyron Chambers arrives from SMU and Tony Louis-Nkuba from Arizona State to bolster the unit.

SPECIALISTS Kicker Ramon Villela hit 15-of-20 field-goal attempts and was 4-for-7 beyond 40 yards. He had a game-winner against Miami (Ohio) and forced OT vs. Utah State with another made field goal late. Australian Matt Choules will handle the punting chores.

FINAL ANALYSIS Five of UNLV's 11 losses since 2023 have come to Boise State, including three in the Mountain West Championship Game. That obstacle is gone with the Broncos' departure to the Pac-12. Can the Rebels win the conference? That will be on the shoulders of Arnold as well as the defense, which surrendered at least 38 points five times last year.

2025 RESULTS (10-4, 6-2 MWC)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 23	Idaho State	W 38-31	Aug. 29	Memphis	1. Jordan Njoku, LB	★★★
Aug. 29	at Sam Houston	W 38-21	Sept. 5	at Hawai'i	2. Jesse Harden, WR	★★★
Sept. 6	UCLA	W 30-23	Sept. 12	at North Texas	3. Jesus Garcia II, OT	★★★
Sept. 20	at Miami (Ohio)	W 41-38	Sept. 26	at Akron	4. Aveon Williams, ATH	★★★
Oct. 4	at Wyoming	W 31-17	Oct. 3	Cal	5. Demari Nunley, WR	★★★
Oct. 11	Air Force	W 51-48	Oct. 10	North Dakota State	6. Tatum Bell Jr., WR	★★★
Oct. 18	at Boise State	L 31-56	Oct. 17	at Air Force	7. Derek Garcia, QB	★★★
Nov. 1	New Mexico	L 35-40	Oct. 31	Northern Illinois	8. Tylen Mathews, CB	★★★
Nov. 8	at Colorado State	W 42-10	Nov. 7	Wyoming	9. Eli Sanchez, IOL	★★★
Nov. 15	Utah State (ot)	W 29-26	Nov. 14	at New Mexico	10. Poe Purcell, DL	★★★
Nov. 21	Hawai'i	W 38-10	Nov. 21	at San José State		
Nov. 29	at Nevada	W 42-17	Nov. 28	Nevada		
Dec. 5	at Boise State #	L 21-38	TEAM INFORMATION Head Coach: Dan Mullen • Record at School: 10-4 (1 year) Career Record: 113-65 (14 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Corey Dennis Defensive Coordinator: Paul Guenther • Location: Las Vegas, Nev. Stadium: Allegiant Stadium (65,000)			
Dec. 23	vs. Ohio %	L 10-17				
#MW Championship %Frisco Bowl						

OFFENSE UTEP is bringing in EJ Colson, the latest touted FCS Incarnate Word quarterback, to revitalize an offense that finished 112th in the FBS in total yards a year ago. Colson, who has three years of eligibility left, threw for 2,142 yards and 16 touchdowns in 10 games last season. UIW went 3-6 in Colson's nine starts. He averaged almost 12 carries per game as a starter and ran for three touchdowns, so the Miners will look to tap into his dual-threat ability.

Missouri transfer running back Tavorus Jones saw limited action with the Tigers for three years, but he showed the ability not only to run between the tackles but also to catch passes out of the backfield. He should be RB1 with help behind him from Buffalo transfer Lamar Sperling and sophomore Elijah McCoy.

Wide receiver Jaylan Brown redshirted last season at Michigan State and will be looked to as a primary downfield target. FCS Northern Colorado transfer Carver Cheeks turned some heads in the spring as well.

The offensive line will start four transfers along with right tackle Juan Camacho Jr., a native of El Paso.

DEFENSE The secondary will be the strength of a defense that was No. 110 nationally in points allowed a year ago. Safety Xavier Smith is the leader of the backline and had 60 tackles and an interception last season. Corner Justin Content is another trusted veteran.

Linebacker Jayden Wilson was UTEP's second-leading tackler last year with 92, including eight for a loss, and should be an all-league candidate. El Paso native Shay Smith (6-foot-2, 215) is moving from QB to linebacker and will be a factor.

On the defensive line, Ashton Coker returns as a starter inside, and the athletic Derek Burns is expected to provide a spark after missing last season with an injury.

SPECIALISTS Transfer Cade Hechter should be taking over the place-kicking duties after transferring from UT Martin, where he was a second-team FCS All-American after hitting 15-of-17 field goals. Brady Braun is a 245-pound punter from FCS Gardner-Webb. Athletic Kam Thomas should be the primary punt returner.

FINAL ANALYSIS Head coach Scotty Walden enters his third season having won only five games at UTEP. With the Miners stepping up from Conference USA to the Mountain West, things will not get any easier. Oklahoma and Michigan await in September. The hope is that Colson is the real deal at QB and that his weapons pan out. The defense has a lot of questions, which is not what you want against this schedule.

2025 RESULTS (2-10, 1-7 CUSA)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 at Utah State L 16-28	Sept. 5 at Oklahoma	1. Colt Matlock, S ★★★
Sept. 6 Tennessee-Martin W 42-17	Sept. 12 Texas Southern	2. Tylon Hockett, CB ★★★
Sept. 13 at Texas L 10-27	Sept. 19 at Michigan	3. Decorian Thompson, CB ★★★
Sept. 20 ULM L 25-31	Sept. 26 Oregon State	4. JD Wallace, ATH ★★★
Sept. 27 Louisiana Tech L 11-30	Oct. 3 at New Mexico	5. Caynan James, DL ★★★
Oct. 8 Liberty L 8-19	Oct. 10 Nevada	6. DAdrian Tinney-Anderson, IOL ★★★
Oct. 15 at Sam Houston W 35-17	Oct. 17 San José State	7. Eddie Lartigue Jr., IOL ★★★
Oct. 28 at Kennesaw State L 20-33	Oct. 31 at North Dakota St.	8. Kane White-Tinsley, S ★★★
Nov. 8 Jacksonville State L 27-30	Nov. 7 Hawai'i	9. Adarius Hutchinson, S ★★★
Nov. 15 at Missouri State L 24-38	Nov. 14 Wyoming	10. Bodey Weaver, QB ★★★
Nov. 22 New Mexico State L 31-34	Nov. 21 at Air Force	
Nov. 29 at Delaware L 31-61	Nov. 28 at Northern Illinois	<i>*Per Rivals</i>
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Scotty Walden • Record at School: 5-19 (2 years) • Career Record: 39-39 (8 years) • Offensive Coordinators: Joe Pappalardo, Laneear Sampson • Defensive Coordinators: Kyle Beyer, Kelvin Sigler • Location: El Paso, Texas • Stadium: Sun Bowl (45,971)		



KAM THOMAS

SCOUTING THE MINERS

"The [QB] Malachi Nelson situation that played out there last year, there's always a risk in getting the quarterback at your place because they know that they can start. But if you look at the quarterbacks who start off at a high level of college football and transfer down, there are not a lot of success stories. Very few. It was the same thing for him at Boise State. I would imagine there was something where he didn't feel like he was getting the support he needed, and he checked out. [Head coach] Scotty Walden is doing a good job there, but they have had a hard time getting a quarterback in place to make his offense go. If they can do that, they'll have a good year. If not, they'll have a rough year."

— An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (0)

WR	7	Jaylan Brown* (So.)	81	Jeremiah Nash* (Jr.)
WR	5	Carver Cheeks* (Sr.)	24	CJ Simon (Fr.)
WR	80	Marcus Torres (So.)	13	Nik Henry (So.)
LT	54	Jaymon Lamb* (Jr.)	70	Maddox Huber (Fr.)
LG	56	Brian Williams Jr.* (So.)	76	Diego De La Cruz (Fr.)
C	67	Jayden Trapp* (So.)	57	Craig Wydra (So.)
RG	55	Omoruyi Aliu-Otokiti* (Jr.)	71	Preston Perkins (Fr.)
RT	75	Juan Camacho Jr. (Sr.)	73	Tyler Roberts (Fr.)
TE	86	Jordan Andrus (Fr.)	87	Chance Bell* (Jr.)
QB	1	EJ Colson* (So.)	12	Raymond Moore III* (So.)
RB	0	Tavorus Jones* (Jr.)	32	Lamar Sperling* (Jr.)

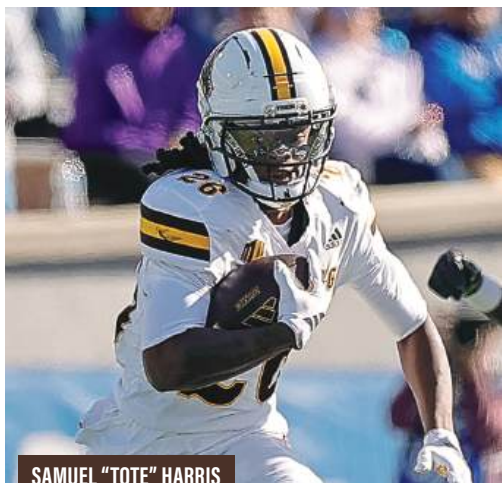
DEFENSE (4)

DE	3	Shakaun Bowser (Sr.)	44	Oryend Fisher* (Jr.)
DL	99	Elijah Fields* (Sr.)	94	Jimmy Leon (Fr.)
DT	90	ASHTON COKER (JR.)	98	Preston Hickey* (Sr.)
DE	11	Derek Burns (Jr.)	25	Royce Wilson (Fr.)
SLB	13	Isaiah Bogerty* (Sr.)	41	Vashon Brunswick II (So.)
MLB	10	JAYDEN WILSON (SR.)	8	Shay Smith (So.)
CB	5	TJ Tillman (So.)	28	Erion Wilkins (So.)
CB	0	JUSTIN CONTENT (JR.)	23	Kaleb Miles* (Jr.)
S	15	Donavan Howard* (Sr.)	16	Esteban Guillory* (Sr.)
S	2	XAVIER SMITH (SR.)	17	Darnell Williams (So.)
S	7	Kode Lowe* (Sr.)	30	Allen Gant (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	48	Cade Hechter* (Sr.)	KR	8	Kam Thomas (Sr.)
P	47	Brady Braun* (Sr.)	PR	8	Kam Thomas (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



SAMUEL "TOTE" HARRIS

SCOUTING THE COWBOYS

"Last year, it was just trying to find their rhythm on offense, but they played in a lot of close games. When you play Wyoming, you know that they're gonna try to slow the game down. They have a system that they want to run. Your guys are gonna be sore the day after you play them. Like, some of their linebackers are still 240 pounds. They're gonna hit ya. They've got an offensive lineman who is gonna be a Day 2 pick in the NFL Draft. They still have massive guys on the offensive line. I think they'll bounce back just fine. ... Their new OC [Christian Taylor] is coming from the Buffalo Bills, so you know that he's gonna have some schematic things ready. I don't know exactly what they're gonna do, but I'm sure that it'll involve running the ball."

—An opposing Mountain West assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	2	ERIC RICHARDSON (SR.)	5	Justin Popovich* (Sr.)
WR	3	Deion DeBlanc (So.)	13	Pierre "PJ" Jackson (Fr.)
WR	9	Jackson Holman (Jr.)	12	Bricen Brantley (Jr.)
LT	70	REX JOHNSEN (SR.)	77	Josiah Petaia (Jr.)
LG	52	Chandler Donaway* (Sr.)	76	Quinn Grovesteen-Matchey (Jr.)
C	51	Jason Maciejczak* (Jr.)	66	Johnathan Bush (Fr.)
RG	50	Giovanni Panozzo (So.)	73	Caleb Hall (So.)
RT	63	BRAYLON JENKINS (SO.)	75	Cooper Lawson (Fr.)
TE	89	Jake Wilson (Jr.)	83	Kyle Frendt (So.)
QB	6	Tyler Hughes* (Sr.)	7	Mason Drube (Fr.)
RB	26	SAMUEL "TOTE" HARRIS (SO.)	8	Markell Holman* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	21	Jack Dunkley (Sr.)	58	Jordan Turnbull (Jr.)
DT	92	Dante Drake (Jr.)	95	Caleb Robinson (Sr.)
DT	98	Jayden Williams (Jr.)	44	Ja'Quan Redfern* (Jr.)
DE	11	Esiaia Bogar (Sr.)	99	Donnie Wingate (Sr.)
MLB	42	Ethan Stuhlsatz (Sr.)	2	Anthony Beavers* (Sr.)
OLB	26	Gary Rutherford (So.)	16	Karson Butts (So.)
CB	0	Tyson Shamsid-Deen (So.)	15	David Leonard (So.)
CB	8	Logan Mackey* (Jr.)	3	Ian Bell (Jr.)
NB	12	DESMAN HEARNS (SR.)	9	Travis Franklin Jr.* (Sr.)
S	23	JONES THOMAS (JR.)	4	Jett Vincent* (Jr.)
S	5	Brooklyn Cheek (So.)	6	Kaiden Kimble-Turner (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	47	Erik Sandvik (Jr.)	KR	3	Deion DeBlanc (So.)
P	18	Bart Edmiston (Sr.)	PR	3	Deion DeBlanc (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



WYOMING COWBOYS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 110 | MWC PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 2-6 MWC

OFFENSE If there is reason for optimism for a Cowboys offense that averaged only 16 points per game last year, it starts at quarterback. Wyoming welcomes Tyler Hughes from FCS William & Mary, where he threw for 2,330 yards and 20 touchdowns and ran for 670 yards and 11 scores. Hughes worked with new offensive coordinator Christian Taylor at W&M before Taylor left for the NFL. The two are reunited in Laramie.

Running back Samuel "Tote" Harris is back after leading the team in rushing as a true freshman with 558 yards and 5.6 yards per carry. FCS Western Illinois transfer Markell Holman, who led the Ohio Valley Conference in rushing last season with 1,063 yards, will spell him.

Deion DeBlanc is a slot receiver who is also a dynamic return specialist and will be the leader of a young group. Eric Richardson saw some spot duty, while Jackson Holman battled injuries.

Wyoming traditionally has featured the tight end, and there are two good ones on hand in Jake Wilson and Kyle Frendt.

The offensive line returns both starting tackles, and the coaches are excited about Nebraska transfer center Jason Maciejczak.

DEFENSE Ethan Stuhlsatz takes over at middle linebacker and had a very strong spring both physically and in his leadership role of lining up the defense. Wyoming will count on him to lead a unit that finished fifth in the Mountain West Conference in total defense. Gary Rutherford will join him as the linebacker group turns over. USC transfer Anthony Beavers is also one to watch.

In the secondary, safety Jones Thomas is the leading returning tackler and one of two returning starters on the backline. He had two interceptions and four pass breakups a year ago and will be a candidate for all-league honors. Nickel Desman Hearn is the other returning starter.

Up front, defensive tackle Dante Drake returns after missing all of 2025 with an Achilles injury. He should be the top player on the line, along with veteran Jayden Williams.

SPECIALISTS Both punter Bart Edmiston and placekicker Erik Sandvik return, with Edmiston a candidate for all-league honors after he averaged 46.1 yards per kick a year ago. DeBlanc averaged 16.7 yards per punt return and took one back for a touchdown.

FINAL ANALYSIS The necessary offensive turnaround will depend on Hughes at quarterback, and the arrow was pointing up in spring ball. The defense will have a lot of new faces, but it looks strong up the middle at all three levels and will have a chance to keep Wyoming in games. Head coach Jay Sawvel's first bowl appearance in his third season is a possibility in a weakened MWC.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 2-6 MWC)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 28	at Akron	W	10-0	Sept. 5	at Colorado State	1. Colin Ford, TE	★★★
Sept. 6	Northern Iowa	W	31-7	Sept. 12	Northern Colorado	2. Pierce Decker, OT	★★★
Sept. 13	Utah	L	6-31	Sept. 19	at Central Michigan	3. Jonathan Percy, IOL	★★★
Sept. 20	at Colorado	L	20-37	Sept. 26	Hawai'i	4. Jackson Garrett, IOL	★★★
Oct. 4	UNLV	L	17-31	Oct. 3	at North Dakota St.	5. Karson Butts, LB	★★★
Oct. 11	San José State	W	35-28	Oct. 10	at San José State	6. Jordan Styles, WR	★★★
Oct. 18	at Air Force	L	21-24	Oct. 17	Northern Illinois	7. Taylor Hasselbeck, QB	★★★
Oct. 25	Colorado State	W	28-0	Oct. 24	Air Force	8. Beck Haswell, ATH	★★★
Nov. 1	at San Diego State	L	7-24	Nov. 7	at UNLV	9. Therman Williams, CB	★★★
Nov. 15	at Fresno State	L	3-24	Nov. 14	at UTEP	10. Mason Wright, EDGE	★★★
Nov. 22	Nevada	L	7-13	Nov. 21	New Mexico		
Nov. 29	at Hawai'i	L	7-27	Nov. 28	UConn		

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Jay Sawvel • Record at School: 7-17 (2 years) • Career Record: 7-17 (2 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Christian Taylor • Defensive Coordinator: Aaron Bohl • Location: Laramie, Wyo. • Stadium: War Memorial Stadium (29,811)